

T1-02: Solo Living Americans

Stage 4M-T-A Persona Needs Report — Lite Mode

Macro-Trends Identity Pipeline | Gather Inc.

Report Date: 2026-03-09 **Pipeline Stage:** 4M-T-A (Lite) **Quadrant:** BUILD **Primary T2 Focus:** T2-04 (First-Time Independent Adults) — acquisition volume anchor **Mode:** Lite — 5 factors × 5 Q&As (25 total), Factor 6 Lite (4 dimensions), no tier-variant interview

TABLE OF CONTENTS

- 1. Segment Overview
 - Segment Definition
 - Market Sizing
 - Segment Stratification
 - Named Persona Profile
 - Notable Profiles (3)
- 2. Core Factor Analysis
 - Factor 1: Social Life & Leisure (Anchor)
 - Factor 2: Spending & Financial Habits
 - Factor 3: Needs & Aspirations
 - Factor 4: Fears & Pain Points
 - Factor 5: Product Landscape & Switching Behavior
- 3. Factor 6: Switching Profile (Lite — 4 Dimensions)
- 4. Executive Brief

SECTION 1: SEGMENT OVERVIEW

Segment Definition

Solo Living Americans are the 38 million adults in the United States who live in single-person households — a population that has more than doubled in proportional share since 1970, when only 17% of households had one occupant. Today that figure is 29% and rising. This is not a residual population of people who haven’t yet coupled up. It is a structurally growing, demographically diverse community shaped by declining marriage rates, extended young-adult independence, rising divorce rates, and longer post-widowhood lifespans. Solo living is increasingly a deliberate architecture of adult life, not a waiting room.

The segment encompasses meaningfully different identity communities under one structural roof. At the younger end sits T2-04 — the first-time independent adult, 18-26, freshly off their parents’ phone plan, signed their first lease, and navigating the adulting curriculum in real time. At the intentional center sits T2-03 — women 25-50 who have actively chosen singlehood, built financial independence, and reject the cultural assumption that partnership is the natural end-state of adult life. Threading through both is a third-party force: the structural economics of solo living, in which every subscription, every utility, and every service plan is carried by one income and one decision-maker.

For telecommunications, the implications are direct and commercially significant. Solo householders are exclusively individual-plan buyers — there is no family plan to defer to, no partner to coordinate with, no employer plan covering their line. They are also among the most switching-mobile consumers in the category: no family plan coordination friction, no contract lock-in from a joint account, and acute price sensitivity driven by the arithmetic of single-income living. Carriers have never built a product specifically for this identity. That gap is the opportunity.

Market Sizing

Metric	Figure	Source
Total single-person households, U.S.	37.9M	Census Bureau, 2023
Growth from 2015	+4.2M (from 33.7M)	Census Bureau, 2023
Projected 2028	40M+	Pew Research Center, 2024
Share of all U.S. households	29%	Census Bureau, 2023
Women ages 25-54 unpartnered, 2024	37% (up from 29% in 1990)	Pew Research Center, 2024
Median income, single-person HH	~\$42,000	BLS Consumer Expenditure Survey, 2023
Single-line premium over family per-line rate	40–60%	CNET Wireless Plan Analysis, 2024

Metric	Figure	Source
Annual new entrants to first independent living	~4M	NCES, Census Bureau, 2023

Growth trajectory: The solo-living population is structurally expanding. Marriage rates hit an all-time U.S. low in 2024 (Pew Research, 2024). Young adults are delaying or forgoing partnership at rates with no modern precedent. Divorce among adults 50+ (gray divorce) now represents 40% of all U.S. divorces (Pew Research, 2023). None of these trends is reversing. The 40M+ projection by 2028 is conservative.

Bimodal age distribution: The T1-02 population peaks at two moments: ages 25-34 (post-college, pre-coupling or intentionally solo) and 65+ (widowhood, post-divorce). This report focuses primarily on the 25-34 cohort (T2-04 and T2-03), which represents the highest commercial priority by switching intent, CAC, and ARPU potential.

Segment Stratification

Tier	Label	Share	Description
Tier 1	Core — Intentional Solo Identity	15%	Self-identified solo-by-choice; active community participation (r/solotravel, #singlebychoice); uses “self-partnered,” “singlism,” “solo date” language; high brand-equity potential
Tier 2	Active — Life-Stage Independent	30%	First-time independent adults (T2-04) and recently divorced/separated solos; actively establishing solo life infrastructure; highest switching intent; community participation through r/personalfinance, #adulting
Tier 3	Peripheral — Practical Solo	35%	Living alone by circumstance rather than strong identity; price-sensitive individual-plan buyers; responsive to value messaging; limited community affiliation around solo living specifically
Tier 4	Adjacent — Reluctant or Transitional	20%	Recently separated, newly relocated, or seniors living alone; solo living is recent or unwanted; practical needs dominate; community ties to divorce support, senior networks, or prior couple identity

Total: 100%

Named Persona Profile

Name: Jordan Reyes **Age:** 23 **Location:** Austin, TX **Occupation:** UX researcher, marketing agency (18 months post-college) **Income:** ~\$52,000

Jordan graduated from UT Austin, stayed in the city, and signed her first solo lease eight months ago after living with three roommates during her first year of work. She finally has her own apartment — a one-bedroom in East Austin she can almost afford — and the phone plan to match. She aged off her parents’ plan the month she moved out, spent two weeks comparing Reddit threads on Mint vs. Visible vs. T-Mobile, and landed on a plan she’s still not sure about. Jordan loves her independence. She also does a mild panic calculation every month when rent, utilities, streaming, and subscriptions come out of one paycheck. She’s building an adult life that feels like hers, and she wants every product she pays for to reflect that.

Apps and platforms: TikTok, Reddit (r/personalfinance, r/frugal, r/Austin), Spotify, Notion, Duolingo, VSCO, Apartment Therapy, Splitwise (still used with old roommates for shared expenses), Robinhood (small portfolio, mostly ETFs).

Notable Profiles

- 1. Shani Silver** — Author and podcaster, “A Single Revolution” (2021) and the podcast “The Personals.” New York City. Shani is the most visible advocate for intentional singlehood as an identity — not a relationship status waiting for resolution. Her audience of 100K+ podcast listeners is the community core of T2-03. She coined the framing that “single is a place you live, not a place you pass through,” and her work directly surfaces the language, frustrations, and aspirations that define the intentionally solo identity community.
- 2. Caleb Hammer** — YouTube creator, “Financial Audit,” 2M+ subscribers. Caleb’s content is rooted in transparent financial review — helping young adults understand where their money goes, why their subscriptions are bleeding them, and how to make independent financial decisions. His audience skews exactly T2-04: 18-28, newly independent, anxious about money, hungry for validation that their financial decisions are “adult enough.”
- 3. Bella DePaulo** — Social scientist, author of “Singled Out” (2006) and subsequent research on “singlism” — institutional discrimination against single people in tax policy, health insurance, housing, and social services. DePaulo’s academic work gave the T2-03 community a vocabulary for systemic frustration. She is frequently cited in community discussions about the financial penalty of solo living — including the wireless single-line pricing premium.

SECTION 2: CORE FACTOR ANALYSIS

FACTOR 1: SOCIAL LIFE & LEISURE

Anchor Factor — Community participation, identity signaling, key platforms and rituals

Quantitative Data

Metric	Figure	Source
TikTok #adulting views	8B+	TikTok, 2025
r/personalfinance members	19M+	Reddit, 2025
r/internetparents members (adulting advice community)	1.1M+	Reddit, 2025
Instagram #solotravel posts	11M+	Instagram, 2025
Solo Female Travelers Facebook group members	1M+	Facebook, 2025
r/solotravel subscribers	2.3M	Reddit, 2025
"Self-partnered" Google search growth, 2019–2024	+340%	Google Trends, 2024

Interview — Jordan Reyes, T2-04 (Active Tier)

Q1. How do you spend your free time now that you have your own place? What does a typical weekend look like?

“Honestly? A lot of it is still figuring out how to be alone in a way that feels good rather than just... alone. I’ll do a solo Saturday morning — coffee at this place on South Congress, read something, maybe walk around. Then I’ll do something social in the afternoon, usually with work friends or people from this young professionals group I joined on Meetup. Sundays I’m on my phone way too much. Reddit, TikTok, a lot of personal finance content. I’m still building my social infrastructure here. It doesn’t look like I thought it would.”

Q2. Where do you feel most connected to other people who are figuring out the same things you are?

“Reddit. Specifically r/personalfinance and this subreddit called r/internetparents where you ask questions you’d normally ask your parents — like ‘is this a normal electric bill’ or ‘what does a W-2 actually mean.’ It’s genuinely caring. People answer like they care about you. TikTok has this whole #adulting thing, which is funny and relatable, but Reddit is where I actually go when I need a real answer. There’s something about knowing millions of people are in the exact same confused position that makes it feel less embarrassing.”

Q3. How does your solo living identity show up in how you present yourself — to friends, online, anywhere?

“I mean, I don’t go around announcing ‘I live alone and I love it’ — that would be weird. But I do feel a kind of quiet pride about it. My apartment is genuinely mine. I chose everything in it. When friends come over and comment on how it looks, that matters to me more than I’d probably admit. Online I follow a lot of ‘first apartment’ content — Apartment Therapy, those TikToks where people do studio tours — and I’ve made my own space that I’m kind of proud of. It’s my proof that I’m doing this.”

Q4. What communities or groups have you joined or sought out since moving out on your own?

“Meetup has been huge for me — I joined a book club and a hiking group when I first moved, before I really had a social network here. I’m also in a few Discord servers — one for people who work in UX, one that’s basically a personal finance nerd group. And I’m starting to follow some creators on TikTok who are specifically about solo living well — like budgeting solo, cooking for one, solo travel. It’s its own little ecosystem that I didn’t know existed before I needed it.”

Q5. What would make you feel like a brand or company actually got what your life is like right now?

“If they talked to me like being on my own is a real choice and not a consolation prize. Every phone ad I see is either for families or for couples. Even the ‘individual plan’ language sounds like an apology — like ‘sorry you don’t have a family to bundle with.’ If someone made a plan that was like ‘you’re one person, this is built for you, it’s not a discounted family plan minus four people’ — that would feel completely different. Like someone actually noticed I exist.”

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
Solo identity is expressed through spaces and choices, not explicit self-labeling	Brand should celebrate the apartment, the independent plan, the solo Saturday — not the absence of a partner
r/personalfinance and r/internetparents are the primary trust communities — functional questions answered with community warmth	Reddit channel integration (organic, not sponsored) should be a primary acquisition pathway
TikTok #adulting is a content format, not just a hashtag — first apartment tours,	Content marketing should lead with these formats, not carrier-generic video ads

Finding	Strategic Implication
“adulting wins,” solo meal prep are the ritual media	
The “individual plan” language reads as apologetic, not aspirational	Rename the category: “solo plan,” “built for one,” or “one-person plan” — not “individual” or “single line”
Social infrastructure-building is the central activity of this life stage — Meetup, Discord, young professional groups	Partnership and community presence at the places this persona shows up would outperform broadcast advertising

FACTOR 2: SPENDING & FINANCIAL HABITS

Quantitative Data

Metric	Figure	Source
Median monthly wireless spend, single-subscriber	\$65–\$80	CTIA / J.D. Power, 2024
Single-line premium over comparable family per-line rate	40–60%	CNET Wireless Plan Analysis, 2024
Median monthly rent, solo apartment, Austin TX	\$1,450	Apartment List National Rent Report, 2025
Median monthly discretionary income after essentials, age 22-28	\$300–\$600	Federal Reserve Consumer Finance Survey, 2022
Subscription cancellation rate, 18-30 age group	40% cancelled at least 1 subscription in past 6 months	C+R Research Subscription Economy Report, 2024

Interview — Jordan Reyes, T2-04 (Active Tier)

Q1. How do you think about your phone plan spending in the context of everything else you’re paying for?

“It’s one of those things I know I’m probably overpaying for but haven’t fixed yet. My rent is my biggest stress — it’s like 30% of my take-home, which everyone told me is the rule, but the rule feels brutal when it’s actually your money. My phone is in that middle category: too expensive to ignore, not expensive enough to make me feel urgency right now. I’m on some T-Mobile plan that was around \$65 a month when I set it up. I know I could probably get the same thing for \$35 on Mint or Visible, but I haven’t made myself do the research.”

Q2. How do you decide what subscriptions are worth keeping and which you cut?

“I basically did an audit last month — wrote everything down for the first time. It was embarrassing. Netflix, Hulu, Spotify, iCloud storage, a random app I forgot about, gym that I definitely don’t use enough. I cut the gym and one streaming service. Phone was on the list as ‘look into this’ but it survived. What I keep comes down to whether I’d notice it being gone tomorrow. Spotify survives every audit. Netflix gets negotiated every few months. Phone is hard to cut because switching feels complicated, even though I know it probably isn’t.”

Q3. What would need to be true for a cheaper phone plan to feel worth switching to?

“I’d need to believe the coverage is real, not just technically real. I’ve heard horror stories about MVNOs where you’re on the same tower but you get deprioritized and your speeds tank. If someone could prove to me — actually prove it, not just say it — that I’d get the same experience, I’d switch immediately. The \$20-30 I’d save matters. It’s not life-changing, but over a year that’s \$300, which is basically a flight. I’d also want the switching process to not feel like a project. Give me like 15 minutes and I’m in.”

Q4. Does it bother you that being a solo subscriber costs more per line than being on a family plan?

“Wait, is that actually true? I kind of suspected it, but I didn’t know the number. That’s genuinely unfair. It’s the same thing that happens with solo travel — single supplement fees, shared room pricing that punishes you for not having a plus-one. It feels like the whole pricing system is built assuming you’ll pair up eventually, and until you do, you pay more. It bothers me more than I want it to. It’s not a huge amount but it’s a principle thing. Why am I being penalized for being on my own?”

Q5. If a carrier designed a plan specifically for people living solo — priced fairly for one person — would you switch for it?

“Yes. I mean, I’d check the reviews first — I’m not going to hand over my phone plan based on vibes. But if the coverage checked out and the price was better, and it was clearly designed for someone like me rather than being a stripped-down family plan with one seat... I think that would genuinely move me. The fact that no one has done this yet is kind of wild. There are 38 million people living alone. We’re just supposed to be okay paying the singles tax on everything?”

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
The single-line pricing penalty is largely invisible to this persona — surfacing it creates immediate emotional resonance and activation	“End the solo tax” should be the primary value claim in acquisition messaging, with explicit \$X saved/year calculation
Switching is a “someday” project, not an urgent task — the barrier is perceived complexity, not dissatisfaction	Frictionless onboarding (15-min switch, number port in <24 hours) must be a core product promise and a marketing claim
Subscription audit behavior is common and recent — this persona is in an active cost-optimization mode	Acquisition campaigns should time to post-audit moments: January, post-tax season, and post-move
Coverage credibility is the primary switching barrier — “same coverage” is not believed without proof	Third-party coverage verification (RootMetrics, Ookla) must be front-loaded in acquisition flow, not buried in fine print
Solo pricing fairness has emotional charge (“principle thing”) beyond the dollar amount	Pricing parity messaging should invoke fairness and dignity, not just savings math

FACTOR 3: NEEDS & ASPIRATIONS

Quantitative Data

Metric	Figure	Source
Young adults (18-29) reporting “adulthood anxiety” as significant life stressor	71%	APA Stress in America, 2023
Solo travelers (primarily women) market growth rate	15%+ CAGR	Allied Market Research, 2024
Women ages 25-34 identifying financial independence as top life priority	64%	Pew Research, 2023
First-apartment residents who used Reddit or TikTok for major purchase decisions in past year	68%	Morning Consult Gen Z Financial Behavior Report, 2024

Interview — Jordan Reyes, T2-04 (Active Tier)

Q1. What are you most trying to build or figure out in your life right now?

“I want to feel like I actually know what I’m doing. Not perform knowing what I’m doing — actually know. That means getting my finances to a place where I’m not anxious every time a bill drops. It means having a social life that isn’t dependent on my work schedule. It means building something that’s mine — not a life I inherited from my parents’ expectations, not a life I copied from whoever seems to have it figured out on Instagram. I’m figuring out what my version of adulthood looks like. That feels urgent and exciting and sometimes terrifying simultaneously.”

Q2. What does “doing well” look like to you in five years?

“I want to have savings that actually feel like savings — not just ‘I haven’t overdrafted this month.’ I want to travel solo at least once a year somewhere I’ve never been. I want to feel confident in my career, like I’ve built something with my own name on it. I’m genuinely not sure whether I want to be coupled or not in five years — I think I’m okay either way. That’s actually new for me. I used to assume partnership was the obvious next step. Now I’m realizing I’m building a life I actually like on my own, and I’ll see what fits into it.”

Q3. What’s something you feel like no one has built specifically for people like you?

“A phone plan, honestly — but also a financial system. Everything assumes you’re either young-and-broke-and-don’t-care or married-with-a-household-income. I’m in this weird middle where I make decent money, I care about where it goes, I’m making all my own decisions, and every product I encounter either talks down to me or treats me like I should be sharing it with someone. I want a bank account that’s built for solo finances. I want a phone plan that’s priced for one person without apology. I want products that see me as a complete unit, not a household waiting to happen.”

Q4. What do you hope your phone and connectivity actually do for your life — beyond just calls and data?

“Connectivity is how I access everything. My social life is mediated through my phone. My job partly happens on it. When I’m using Reddit at midnight to figure out whether I got a fair electricity quote, that’s my phone being like... the adult mentor I don’t have in the room. I want it to be reliable enough that I never think about it. I don’t want to manage my phone. I want it to just work, quietly, while I build my life. The idea of worrying about coverage or data caps or whether I’ll get throttled on a bad month — I want zero mental real estate spent on that.”

Q5. Is there a part of your solo living identity that you feel like you can’t talk about — something complicated?

“Yeah. Honestly — loneliness. There’s a version of solo living that looks amazing: solo travel, your own apartment, total freedom, self-partnered queen energy. And a lot of that is real. But there are also Sundays that are just long and quiet, when you realize there’s no one who’s automatically checking in. I don’t want to complain about it because I know people who are in relationships that make them lonelier. And I genuinely chose this right now. But the Instagram version of solo living skips that part. I’m working on sitting with both — the real freedom and the real quiet.”

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
The core unstated need is to feel like a complete, competent adult — not a person in transition	Brand positioning must treat the solo subscriber as a finished individual, not a person en route to partnership
Aspirations are oriented around self-authored identity: solo travel, financial autonomy, career ownership — not relationship status	Product benefits should anchor to enabling this self-authored life, not compensating for absence of partnership
The “I want products that see me as a complete unit” statement is the sharpest brief for product design	“Built for one” is not a pricing message — it is an identity recognition message
Loneliness is the honest undercurrent beneath the confident solo narrative — but it is not the primary product hook	Do not market to loneliness; acknowledge it with respect in brand tone. The persona wants celebration of independence, not acknowledgment of its hardships
Reliability and invisibility are the unstated product requirements — “I don’t want to manage my phone”	Zero-friction service design (no throttling surprises, no annual rate hikes, proactive account alerts) is as important as price

FACTOR 4: FEARS & PAIN POINTS

Quantitative Data

Metric	Figure	Source
Young adults (22-30) reporting financial anxiety as a frequent or constant experience	74%	Bankrate Financial Security Survey, 2024
Solo adults reporting feeling “economically penalized” for single status in at least one spending category	61%	Pew Research, 2023
Wireless consumers citing “unexpected charges or rate changes” as top dissatisfaction driver	42%	J.D. Power U.S. Wireless Purchase Experience Study, 2024
Solo travelers reporting safety as primary solo travel concern	54% (women)	Solo Travel Network, 2024

Interview — Jordan Reyes, T2-04 (Active Tier)

Q1. What’s the financial fear that sits in the back of your head most consistently?

“One unexpected thing breaking everything. Like, what if my car breaks down and that’s \$1,200 I don’t have sitting in savings? What if I get sick and the bill is real? I don’t have a safety net the way my parents did — they had each other’s income, their families nearby. It’s just me. My emergency fund is barely three months of expenses right now and I’m trying to build it but it’s slow when there’s only one income. The math is just harder when it’s one person. That’s not a complaint, it’s just arithmetic. But it’s a fear.”

Q2. What frustrates you most about the products and services that are supposed to serve you right now?

“The assumptions baked in. Insurance assumes you have a partner to be on your policy. Gym memberships sell you a ‘family package’ that’s half the price per person. Phone plans penalize me for not being on a family plan. Taxes give married people a break I don’t get. It’s everywhere. I don’t want charity. I want pricing and products that weren’t designed with the assumption that I’ll eventually be half of a couple. I exist now. I’m not a provisional person.”

Q3. What’s your biggest fear about your phone plan or carrier specifically?

“Honestly? That I’ll get stuck. I hate the idea of being locked in — either by a device payment plan that’s actually a contract, or by inertia, or because switching feels complicated enough that I just don’t. That’s what’s happening right now. I’m not happy enough to be glad I’m here, but I’m not unhappy enough to make myself do something. That gap is where carriers make their money off people like me. I know it and I can’t seem to get out of it.”

Q4. What would make you distrust a brand targeting people like you?

“If it felt like they discovered ‘solo people’ as a marketing angle without actually caring. If the ‘solo plan’ was just a regular plan with a new name and a picture of someone hiking alone on the website. I have pretty good radar for that. I read the fine print now. I check Reddit before I buy anything significant. If the community hasn’t vetted it — or worse, if there are a bunch of

threads about hidden fees or throttling or bait-and-switch — I’m not touching it. Authenticity is the bar. I’m not asking for perfection, I’m asking to not be tricked.”

Q5. What about solo living do you wish you’d been better prepared for?

“The mental load. Nobody told me that being an adult means holding every single administrative thing in your head simultaneously. Insurance renewal, lease renewal, when to call the landlord versus just dealing with it, whether that weird sound from the fridge is urgent or not. When you’re coupled, presumably you share that. When it’s just you, it all lives in your head. My phone plan is one of 40 things I’m managing. The fact that carriers make switching feel complicated adds to that load when it should be reducing it. I want less to manage, not more.”

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
The solo financial risk is structurally real: one income, no backup — not just anxiety but material exposure	Product design should consider emergency-support features (bill pause, payment grace period) that reflect one-income reality
“I’m not a provisional person” — the deepest fear is being treated as temporary or incomplete by the products around her	Brand voice must treat the solo subscriber as a permanent, complete customer — not a family-plan candidate in waiting
Inertia is the primary churn and non-acquisition driver — the persona knows she’s overpaying and hasn’t fixed it	Frictionless switching design (15-minute port, no device lock required, same-day activation) removes the inertia excuse
Community-vetting (Reddit) is the primary trust mechanism — no amount of advertising overrides r/personalfinance consensus	Organic community reputation management is non-negotiable; transparent pricing and no hidden fees are the foundation
The administrative mental load of solo life is a genuine pain — the persona wants fewer things to manage, not more	Plan design should minimize ongoing management: no annual renewal negotiations, proactive rate alerts, simple billing

FACTOR 5: PRODUCT LANDSCAPE & SWITCHING BEHAVIOR

Quantitative Data

Metric	Figure	Source
MVNO market share of U.S. wireless subscribers	15.4%	CTIA, 2024
Consumer willingness to switch for \$10+/month savings, 18-34 age group	67%	J.D. Power, 2024
Average time to switch wireless carriers, including port	2–4 hours (perceived) vs. 20–45 min (actual)	Opensignal, 2023
Solo subscribers currently on family plans (parents or partners)	~28% of 18-29 solo adults	Morning Consult, 2023
Mint Mobile brand awareness, 18-34	71%	YouGov BrandIndex, 2024

Interview — Jordan Reyes, T2-04 (Active Tier)

Q1. What carrier are you on right now, and how did you end up there?

“T-Mobile. After I aged off my parents’ plan — which, embarrassingly, I was on until I was 23 — I spent about two weeks reading Reddit threads and comparing plans. T-Mobile kept coming up as the most reliable coverage in Austin, and I was nervous about doing this for the first time and getting it wrong. Mint Mobile and Visible both seemed cheaper, but I didn’t trust the coverage claims. I ended up spending about \$30 more a month than I probably needed to because I was afraid to make the wrong first decision. I’m not sure I made the right call.”

Q2. What do you know about Mint Mobile or other MVNOs? Have you ever almost switched?

“I know Mint is on T-Mobile’s network, which I did not know until like three months ago when someone posted about it on r/personalfinance. I also know Visible is on Verizon. I almost switched to Mint when my T-Mobile bill went up \$8 randomly and no one could explain why. I got to the checkout page on Mint’s site and then got nervous about the port and just closed the tab. I need someone to make that process feel actually easy. Not ‘easy’ like every bank claims to be easy. Actually, genuinely, 15-minute easy.”

Q3. What would the ideal phone plan for someone like you actually look like?

“Honest pricing — what I pay in month one is what I pay in month 12, no surprises. Good coverage that’s been verified by someone I trust, not just the carrier’s map. A plan that was built for one person and priced like it — not a family plan with three people missing. Maybe something I can actually understand, without going through a comparison spreadsheet every time I need to make a decision. And the ability to switch in and out without feeling like I need to schedule a Saturday afternoon for it.”

Q4. What would make you loyal to a carrier — like, actually stay and recommend them?

“If they didn’t make me feel like a second-class subscriber for being one person. If my bill was the same every month. If their support was useful and fast. I’d talk about it — I tell people about good things I find. When I discovered that YNAB was a real budgeting system and not just an app, I became an evangelist for like six months. If a phone plan made me feel genuinely seen and served, I would absolutely tell people. There aren’t many products that target solo adults as a category of people worth targeting. If one did, I’d notice.”

Q5. What would it take for you to switch to a new carrier today — what’s the actual barrier?

“Time, mostly. And residual fear that I’ll mess something up. I know number porting is supposed to be simple but I’ve never done it. I need the process to be spelled out, like step by step, by someone who’s not the carrier. Reddit people have done this — I’d trust a ‘how to switch in 20 minutes’ thread more than I’d trust the carrier’s own guide. The other thing is I want to know what happens if it goes wrong. Like, is there any recourse? If I port my number and something breaks, am I just stuck? Give me confidence that there’s a person — or a very good AI — who will fix it.”

Insights

Finding	Strategic Implication
The first carrier choice (off parents’ plan) is driven by coverage anxiety and lack of experience — not brand loyalty	Acquisition messaging should lead with coverage proof, not price — save the pricing win for after coverage is established
Cart abandonment at the port step is a real conversion loss — the friction is emotional, not technical	Guided port walkthrough (step-by-step, Reddit-style) should be part of the signup flow — consider a live chat option at this step
YNAB-style evangelism is possible if the product delivers — this persona recommends things she believes in	NPS-driven referral program should launch at month 3 (post-honeymoon), tied to a community framing (“tell people like you”)
Price sensitivity is real but coverage is the gateway — coverage must be proven first for price to close the deal	Two-step acquisition: (1) prove coverage via personalized coverage check with third-party verification; (2) present pricing win
The MVNO education gap is a conversion opportunity — this persona didn’t know Mint uses T-Mobile’s towers until recently	Content marketing around “MVNO 101” reaches this audience in the research phase and builds trust before the sales conversation

FACTOR 6: SWITCHING PROFILE (LITE — 4 DIMENSIONS)

Primary moment: First Solo Apartment | Composite Score: 4.00 | Window: Short (May–August)

Dimension 1: Trigger Mechanism + Force Score

Trigger mechanism: Structural disruption — the persona ages off a parent’s family plan at the point of establishing independent living. This is not a forced dissolution (the parent plan still exists and could theoretically be maintained) but it is a strong structural trigger: signing a first lease and establishing an independent household creates a social expectation and identity motivation to also establish independent service. The decision to leave the parent plan and get one’s own is partly practical, partly a symbolic act of adulthood.

Compound trigger: For T2-04, two triggers reinforce simultaneously — (1) aging off the parent plan (structural, identity-motivated), and (2) first lease signing (logistical, creates the occasion for comprehensive service setup). The convergence of these two events in May-August (graduation season, lease-start season) creates a concentrated acquisition window with high switching intent.

Component	Assessment
Trigger type	Structural disruption + identity transition
Force score	4 out of 5 — strong pull toward switching, not technically forced but socially expected
Compound trigger present?	Yes — lease signing + parent plan exit occur simultaneously
Emotional state tag	Empowered + Anxious — excitement of independence with financial uncertainty underneath

Dimension 2: Annual Volume + Seasonal Distribution

Metric	Figure	Source
Annual new entrants to first independent living	~4M	NCES, Census Bureau, 2023
Subset switching-eligible (off parent plan, no employer plan)	~2.8–3.2M	Estimated from Morning Consult 2023; 28% already on solo plans pre-move
Y/Y trend	Stable — new cohort enters annually, proportional to young adult population	NCES, 2023

Quarterly distribution:

Quarter	Est. Share	Notes
Q1 (Jan–Mar)	10%	Off-cycle movers; spring semester ends; low volume
Q2 (Apr–Jun)	40%	Graduation peak — May–June is highest volume; lease-signing concentrated here
Q3 (Jul–Sep)	35%	August back-to-school; late lease signers; second peak
Q4 (Oct–Dec)	15%	Lower volume; holiday-season movers; some early spring setuppers

Frequency score: 4 out of 5 — 2.8–3.2M eligible switchers per year is a meaningful annual volume with a concentrated seasonal signal.

Dimension 3: Interception Channels (Top 3)

Rank	Channel	Type	Reach	CPA Benchmark	Partnership Required?
1	Reddit (r/personalfinance, r/internetparents, r/adulthood)	Digital / Community	20M+ combined	\$18–\$28 estimated (Tier 2 community + search)	Preferred: community-native posts, AMA activations, no formal partnership required; organic trust-building
2	TikTok (#adulthood, #firstpartment)	Digital / Social	8B+ #adulthood views	\$22–\$35 CPM-based estimated	Creator partnership preferred; UGC-style sponsored content; authenticity-first format
3	Moving and apartment platforms (Apartment List, Zillow, Apartments.com)	Partnership / Digital	~30M annual active users	\$35–\$55 (intent-based, high precision)	Formal partnership required; trigger-point placement at lease-sign confirmation

CPA benchmarks for top 2: - Reddit: Estimated \$18–\$28 CPA with community-native organic integration. Conventional Reddit advertising performs poorly; trust must be earned through helpful content and transparent participation. AMA-style activations in r/personalfinance (moderator-approved, valuable content) have produced documented viral distribution. - TikTok: Estimated \$22–\$35 CPA for creator-partnered content in the #adulthood niche. Authenticity is non-negotiable — scripted-feeling content is called out immediately. Creator vetting for genuine T2-04 audience overlap is essential.

Partnership feasibility for Rank 1 (Reddit): Reddit community strategy requires consistent, authentic presence over 3–6 months before any conversion expectation. Gather should invest in community participation first (answering questions in r/personalfinance, posting transparent carrier comparisons, responding to switching questions) before any formal promotional activity. The conversion pathway from Reddit trust to subscriber is longer but produces lower churn and higher NPS than paid acquisition.

Dimension 4: Window Structure

Component	Assessment
Window type	Short — concentrated May–August, with peak in May–June (graduation) and secondary peak in August (back-to-school)
Peak intent window	May 1 – August 15 (3.5 months); highest density May 15 – June 30
Intent decay curve	Sharp post-August — once leases are signed and plans are established (even suboptimally), inertia sets in rapidly
Window predictability	Date-certain / calendar-predictable — graduation dates are fixed; lease-start cycles are well-documented

Decision journey map:

1. **Awareness** (April–May): Graduating/moving; realizes the parent plan issue is coming; begins passive research — TikTok content, Reddit browsing
2. **Active search** (May–June): Actively comparing plans; Reddit threads, CNET comparisons, carrier websites; high intent but high confusion
3. **Decision** (May–July): Commits to a carrier; often driven by a trusted recommendation (Reddit thread, friend) rather than the carrier’s own marketing
4. **Post-decision lock-in** (July–September): Established on a plan; inertia builds; switching urgency drops sharply even if dissatisfied

Interception timing: Gather must reach this persona in the awareness-to-active-search phase (April–June). Interception at the decision moment without prior trust is less effective — this persona vets before she buys. Engagement through Reddit and TikTok in February–April plants the brand seed before the active decision window opens.

SECTION 3: EXECUTIVE BRIEF

Key Insights

1. **The solo tax is the primary commercial framing.** Single-line subscribers pay 40–60% more per line than family-plan members for functionally equivalent service. This is not widely understood by the T2-04 persona — and the moment she learns the number, there is emotional reaction beyond the math. “Built for one” pricing parity is not a feature; it is a market correction that doubles as brand declaration.
2. **Coverage credibility is the gateway; price is the closer.** This persona will not switch for price alone. Coverage anxiety is the primary switching barrier — particularly for first-time MVNO switchers. Gather must establish coverage credibility (third-party verification, community vouching, transparent coverage check tool) before the savings story lands.
3. **Reddit is the trust infrastructure for this segment.** r/personalfinance (19M+ members) and r/internetparents (1.1M+) are where this persona makes consequential decisions. Authentic community presence — not advertising — is the required distribution model. A positive, unprompted mention in a top-voted r/personalfinance thread outperforms a six-figure media buy.
4. **Inertia is the enemy, not competition.** The T2-04 persona is often on a suboptimal plan by her own admission and hasn’t switched because switching feels like a project. The carrier that makes switching feel genuinely frictionless — 15 minutes, step-by-step, live support at the port — removes the only real barrier for a large segment of this audience.
5. **The seasonal window is exploitable and precise.** 70–75% of first-time-independent plan acquisitions happen May–August. This creates a predictable, calendar-anchored acquisition sprint. Gather’s community-building should begin in February–March; acquisition spend should peak May–June; loyalty investment should begin August.

Identity Tensions

1. **Independence vs. vulnerability.** Jordan celebrates her solo life and is quietly terrified of the math. The tension between “I chose this” pride and “one emergency could wreck me” anxiety is the emotional core of this identity. Products that acknowledge both — the pride and the risk — will feel more real than those that only celebrate.
2. **Completion vs. transitional status.** This persona is in the middle of constructing her adult identity and is simultaneously aware that many products treat her as incomplete — a person on the way to a household, not a finished one. The tension between her internal sense of completeness (“I built this life”) and external product assumptions (“you’ll eventually bundle with a partner”) is active and grating.
3. **Community belonging vs. individual autonomy.** She builds community through Reddit, Discord, Meetup — but the identity she’s building is fundamentally solo. The tension is between the need for peers navigating the same terrain and the insistence that her choices are her own. Products that speak to community validation without undermining individual decision-making respect this tension.

Top Needs

Stated needs: - A phone plan priced fairly for one person, not structured as a family plan minus members - Coverage that matches what she currently has (T-Mobile / major carrier quality) without the single-line premium - Switching that is genuinely frictionless — step-by-step, 15 minutes, live support available - Pricing stability — what she pays in month one is what she pays in month twelve

Unstated needs: - To be recognized as a complete, competent adult — not a household waiting to form - A brand that validates intentional independence as a worthy life architecture - Reduced mental load — fewer things to actively manage, fewer surprises to absorb - Community proof before purchase — not advertising-driven trust but peer-validated trust

Strategic Recommendations

1. **Launch “Built for One” as the brand’s foundational claim.** Position explicitly against the single-line premium: “We built this plan for people who don’t share.” Publish the math — \$X saved per year vs. the average single-line cost from major carriers. Make the pricing comparison tool available before account creation, not after. This is a mission-level claim, not a feature bullet.
2. **Invest in Reddit before paying for ads.** Hire or partner with a community manager who posts authentically in r/personalfinance, r/internetparents, and r/adulthood for 90 days before any promotional intent. Answer real questions about switching. Offer transparent plan comparisons. The cost of this is low; the trust it builds is the primary acquisition asset for this persona. Reddit reputation is non-negotiable infrastructure for T2-04 acquisition.
3. **Design the switching flow as a product.** The plan-switching experience — from “I’m interested” to “my number is ported” — should be a 15-minute guided process with live chat available at the moment of port. Every step should be

explained in plain language. Build a “what if something goes wrong?” FAQ that is honest and reassuring. Reduce cart abandonment at the port step, which is where this persona loses her nerve.

4. **Build a seasonal acquisition sprint around graduation.** April 15 – August 15 is the primary window. February–March: seed community content and trust-building. April: begin TikTok creator partnerships in the #adulting and #firstpartment content vertical. May–June: peak acquisition spend; graduation-adjacent messaging. August: back-to-school push targeting students making first independent plan decisions. This is a campaign structure, not a continuous-spend model.
5. **Design for the T2-03 LTV play simultaneously.** While T2-04 is the acquisition volume story, T2-03 (Intentionally Single Women) is the brand-loyalty story. A solo-specific brand that earns community trust with T2-04 at age 23 retains her through the T2-03 identity at age 31. Product features that serve T2-03 (solo travel eSIM, financial transparency tools, anti-singlism framing) deepen loyalty for the full T1-02 funnel.

Success Metrics

Metric	Target	Measurement Method
Solo-plan subscriber growth, May–Aug window	15,000+ new subscribers in first summer season	Internal subscriber count, cohort-tagged
Reddit brand sentiment, r/personalfinance	Net positive mention ratio >70% (unprompted threads)	Community monitoring; manual thread sampling
Port completion rate (signup → active subscriber)	>85% (industry avg ~75%)	Funnel analytics; drop-off at port step
Month-6 churn rate, T2-04 cohort	<8% (MVNO industry avg ~12%)	Cohort retention analytics
NPS at 90 days, first-time independent subscribers	>55 (telco industry avg ~22)	Post-activation NPS survey

Go/No-Go Recommendation

GO — with seasonal urgency.

The structural case is unambiguous: 38M solo adults, 100% individual-plan buyers, no carrier marketing to the identity, a quantifiable pricing injustice (single-line premium), and a primary acquisition moment (first solo apartment) with 2.8–3.2M eligible switchers annually in a predictable May–August window. The competitive white space is clear. T2-04 is the acquisition engine. T2-03 is the brand-loyalty foundation. Together they make T1-02 the most structurally actionable persona in the Macro-Trends pipeline.

The risks are real but manageable: coverage credibility must be built before price claims land; Reddit authenticity takes 90+ days to develop; the T2-04 identity is life-stage-bound, not permanent (it transitions to T2-03 or general adult identity over time). None of these risks are fatal — they are execution requirements.

Sequencing recommendation: begin community-building now (Q1 2026); launch acquisition sprint May 1, 2026; use summer 2026 cohort data to validate LTV assumptions before committing to full brand investment.

Switching Profile Summary

Primary moment: First Solo Apartment **Composite score:** 4.00 (Force: 4/5; Volume: 4/5) **Window type:** Short — May–August, calendar-predictable **Intent decay:** Sharp after August — inertia sets in rapidly post-move **Top interception channel:** Reddit (r/personalfinance, r/internetparents) — community-native, trust-based **Estimated eligible annual volume:** 2.8–3.2M **Stage 4M-T-B interception concept scope:** Full interception concepts warranted (score 4.0+) **Primary interception timing:** February–March community seeding; April–June acquisition sprint; August secondary push

APPENDIX: REFERENCES

Research Organizations

Organization	Key Data Used	Website
Pew Research Center	Solo living growth, unpartnered women trends, gray divorce rates	pewresearch.org
U.S. Census Bureau	Single-person household count (37.9M), household growth projections	census.gov
Bureau of Labor Statistics	Consumer Expenditure Survey; solo HH median income	bls.gov
American Psychological Association	Adulting anxiety statistics (71%, Stress in America 2023)	apa.org
Federal Reserve	Consumer Finance Survey; discretionary income estimates	federalreserve.gov

Industry Data Sources

Source	Data Used	Website
J.D. Power	Wireless satisfaction, switching intent by age, CPA benchmarks	jdpower.com
CTIA	MVNO market share (15.4%)	ctia.org
Opensignal	Port completion time estimates	opensignal.com
CNET Wireless Plan Analysis	Single-line pricing premium (40–60%)	cnet.com
Morning Consult	Gen Z financial behavior, solo adults on parent plans	morningconsult.com
Bankrate	Financial anxiety statistics	bankrate.com
Allied Market Research	Solo travel market growth rate	alliedmarketresearch.com
YouGov BrandIndex	Mint Mobile awareness	yougov.com

Community Data Sources

Platform	Data Used	URL
Reddit	r/personalfinance (19M+), r/internetparents (1.1M+), r/solotravel (2.3M+)	reddit.com
TikTok	#adulthood (8B+ views), #firstpartment	tiktok.com
Instagram	#solotravel (11M+ posts)	instagram.com
Facebook	Solo Female Travelers (1M+ members)	facebook.com

Academic Sources

Source	Insight	Reference
DePaulo, Bella — “Singled Out”	Institutional discrimination against single adults; singlism framework	W.W. Norton, 2006
Klinenberg, Eric — “Going Solo”	Sociological analysis of solo living as structural shift	Penguin, 2012